

III

PART III

Decisions, pitfalls, quality

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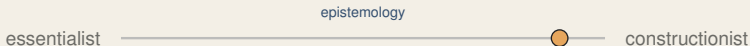
The method is flexible — which means every choice has to be declared, and there are ten well-documented ways to get it wrong.

Four decisions you have to declare

Reflexive TA is theoretically flexible — but never atheoretical. Each choice is a position on a continuum, not a box to tick.

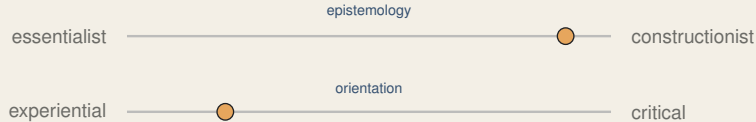
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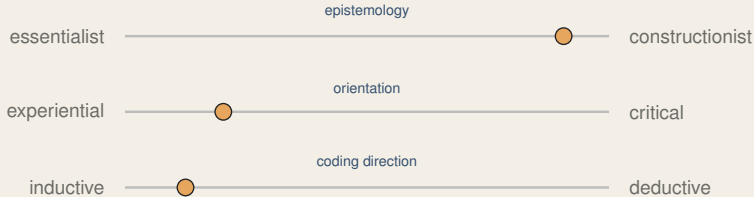
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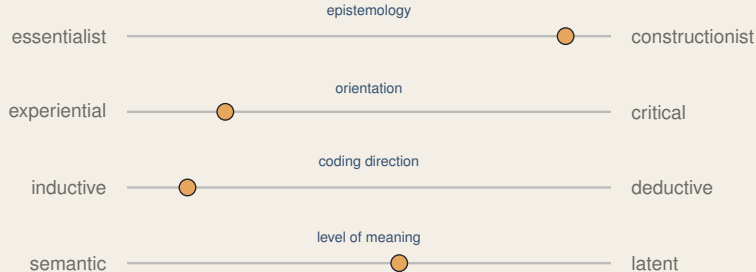
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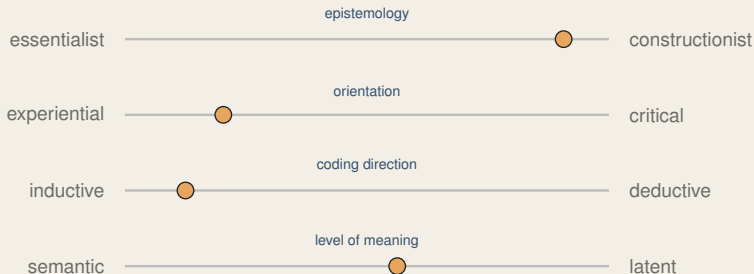
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The knob almost never sits at an end. Byrne's study was mostly inductive *with* a deductive check, and coded semantically *and* latently — **and he said so in writing.**

Ten documented problems — three that matter most

The problem	What it looks like	The fix

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What it looks like

The fix

Assuming TA is one thing

A paper citing four incompatible TA authors at once

Name your variant and stick to it

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Citing without reading

“We followed Braun & Clarke” — then a codebook and a Kappa

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Topics dressed as themes	Themes named <i>Benefits of...</i> , <i>Barriers to...</i>	Find the shared meaning underneath

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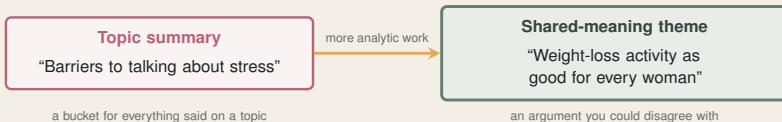
Topic summary

“Barriers to talking about stress”

a bucket for everything said on a topic

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So what counts as quality?

What quality *is*

- A named, justified variant of TA.
- Stated theoretical assumptions — even for inductive work.
- Themes with a central organising concept.
- Extracts that are analysed, not just displayed.

What quality is *not*

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- Consensus between coders.
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In reflexive thematic analysis, chasing “unbiased” coding is not just unnecessary — it is *incoherent*. Subjectivity is the instrument. The published toolkit is a **15-point checklist** (2006) and **20 critical questions** for reviewers (2020).

The takeaway

“*a compass and a map*”

— Braun & Clarke (2020)

Reflexive thematic analysis gives you a direction of travel, not a destination. The six phases are a loop you walk more than once, the themes are things you build rather than find, and the researcher — visibly, deliberately, on the record — is part of the result.

References

- [1] Braun, V. & Clarke, V. (2006). Using thematic analysis in psychology. *Qualitative Research in Psychology*, 3(2), 77–101.
- [2] Braun, V. & Clarke, V. (2019). Reflecting on reflexive thematic analysis. *Qualitative Research in Sport, Exercise and Health*, 11(4), 589–597.
- [3] Braun, V. & Clarke, V. (2020). One size fits all? What counts as quality practice in (reflexive) thematic analysis? *Qualitative Research in Psychology*.
- [4] Byrne, D. (2022). A worked example of Braun and Clarke's approach to reflexive thematic analysis. *Quality & Quantity*, 56, 1391–1412.

Typeset in $\text{\LaTeX}$ with Beamer and TikZ.

Thank you.

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